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The BRICS' dangerous endorsement of 'financial inclusion'

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Coinciding with the 5th Annual Meeting of the BRICS in South Africa in March 2013, the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) released their flagship Human Development Report, *The Rise of the South: Human Progress in a Diverse World*. The latter is a celebration of the BRICS and their 'striking transformation into dynamic major economies with growing political influence'. The Report emphasises how this change is having a 'significant impact' on 'human development progress', as measured by the Human Development Index.

Armed with the recipe for development success, the UNDP recommends several neoliberal strategies that all countries in the South should pursue to ensure that progress be made available to everyone.

First, the South needs to ensure a tighter embrace of global markets. Aside from governments and private enterprises, financial liberalisation involves a new subject: the poor, who have over the past decade been rebranded as the bottom of the pyramid or the unbanked/underbanked. The poor still compose a considerable segment of the population, despite the 'Rise of the South'.

Second, the South needs to adhere to the rules of global governance, i.e. transparency, accountability and rule of law – all of which have been defined by the IMF, World Bank, World Trade Organisation and the G20. The focus on global financial market access and global governance comes together most strikingly in the G20 Principles for Innovative Financial Inclusion of 2010 (hereafter, G20 Principles). In their capacity as members of the G20, leaders of the BRICS countries have been endorsing the financial inclusion agenda as a way